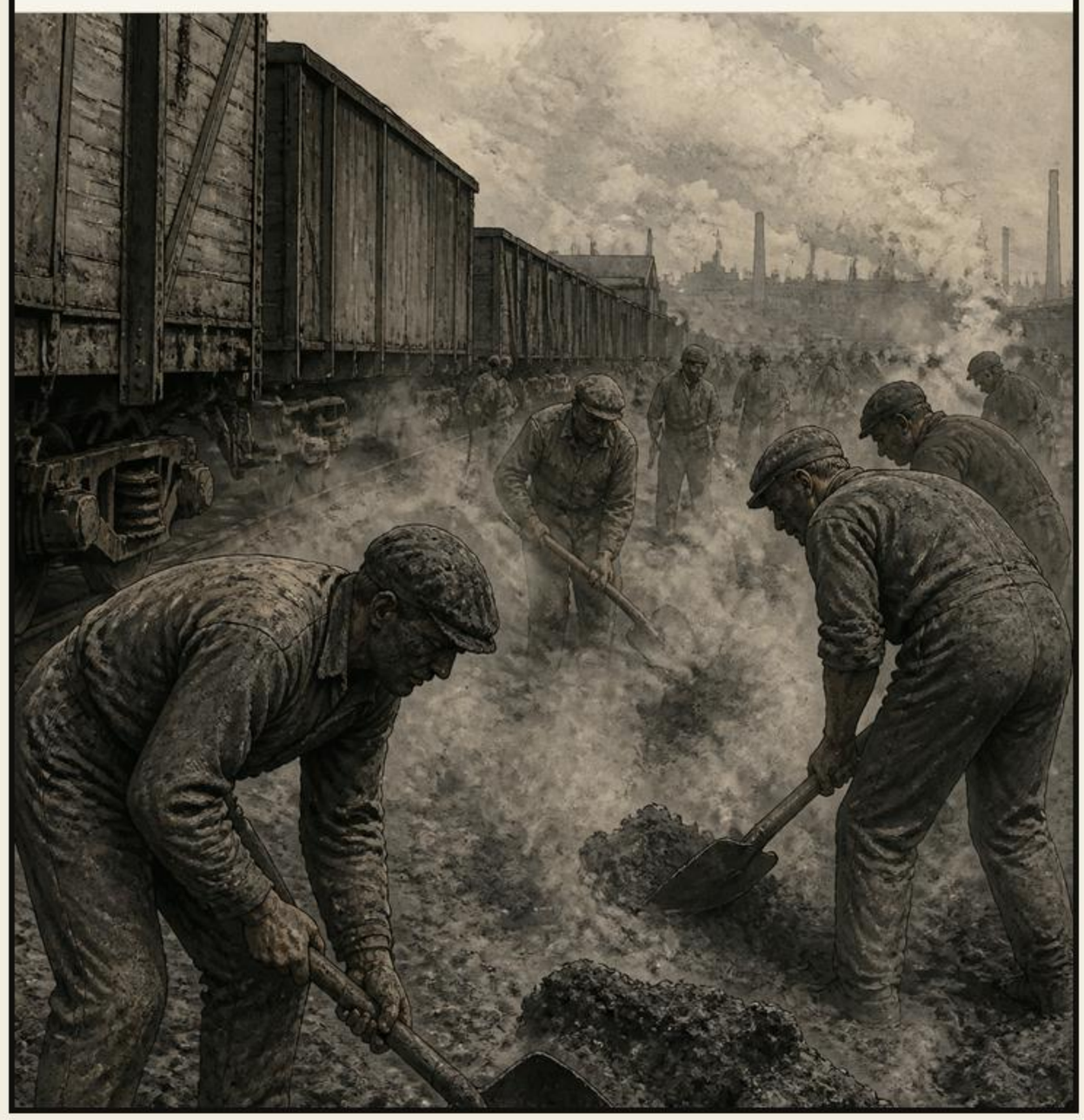
About halfway between West Egg and New York, the motor road hurries to join the railroad and run beside it, shrinking from a certain desolate stretch of land — a valley of ashes.



Ash-grey men move dimly through the powdery air; a line of grey cars crawls in, creaks to rest, and the men swarm up with leaden spades to stir an impenetrable cloud.



Above the bleak dust brood the eyes of Doctor T. J. Eckleburg — blue and gigantic, gazing from huge yellow spectacles set there by some forgotten oculist and left to dim under sun and rain.



The train always halts there at least a minute — and it was because of that halt that I first met Tom Buchanan's mistress. He'd tanked up at luncheon, and his determination for my company bordered on violence. Tom Buchanan spoke.



I followed him over a low whitewashed fence, a hundred yards along the road under Doctor Eckleburg's persistent stare.



The interior was bare, a dust-covered Ford crouched in the corner. The proprietor came out wiping his hands—blond, spiritless, faintly handsome—and a damp gleam of hope sprang into his eyes.



Tom's voice went cold, and Wilson's faded out. Tom threatened to sell the car somewhere else



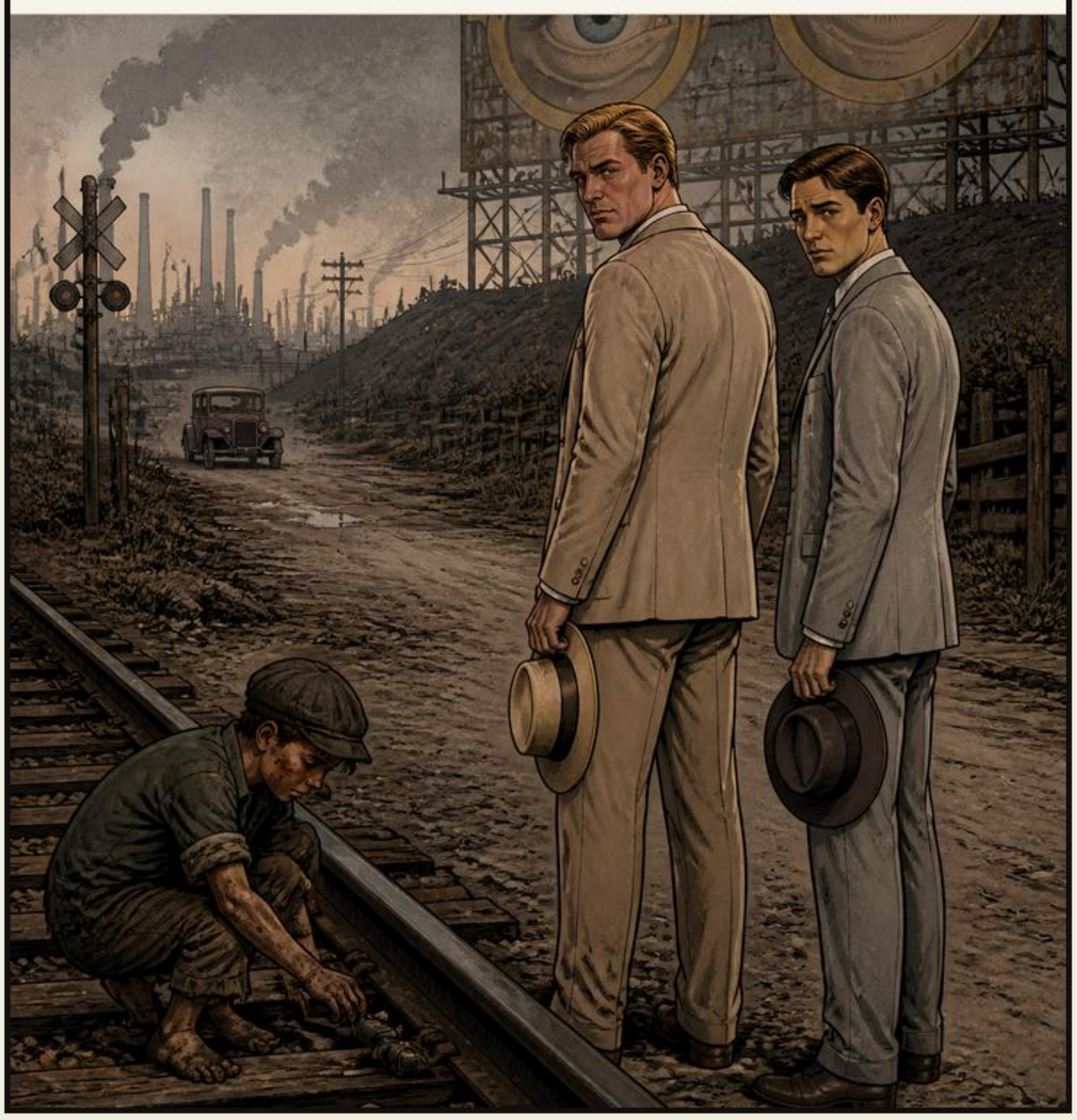
Then footsteps on the stairs—and she walked through her husband as if he were a ghost, and shook hands with Tom, flush in the eye. Myrtle spoke.



Tom set the meeting while her husband fetched chairs from the office. Tom spoke.



We waited down the road, out of sight. Days before the Fourth, a grey child laid torpedoes along the rail. Tom spoke at length.



We rode up to New York—she in another car. By the newsstand she'd already bought Town Tattle, a movie magazine, cold cream, and a flask of perfume.



We slid out of the station into glowing sunshine—until she tapped the glass. Vendor called the puppy more of an Airedale and named the price



Tom settled the matter of the puppy as he settled everything else.



Fifth Avenue lay warm and soft on the summer Sunday—almost pastoral; I half expected a flock of white sheep around the corner.



At 158th Street the cab stopped at one slice in a long white cake of apartment-houses, and Mrs. Wilson swept in like a returning queen. Myrtle Wilson announced that she would call her sister and have friends up.



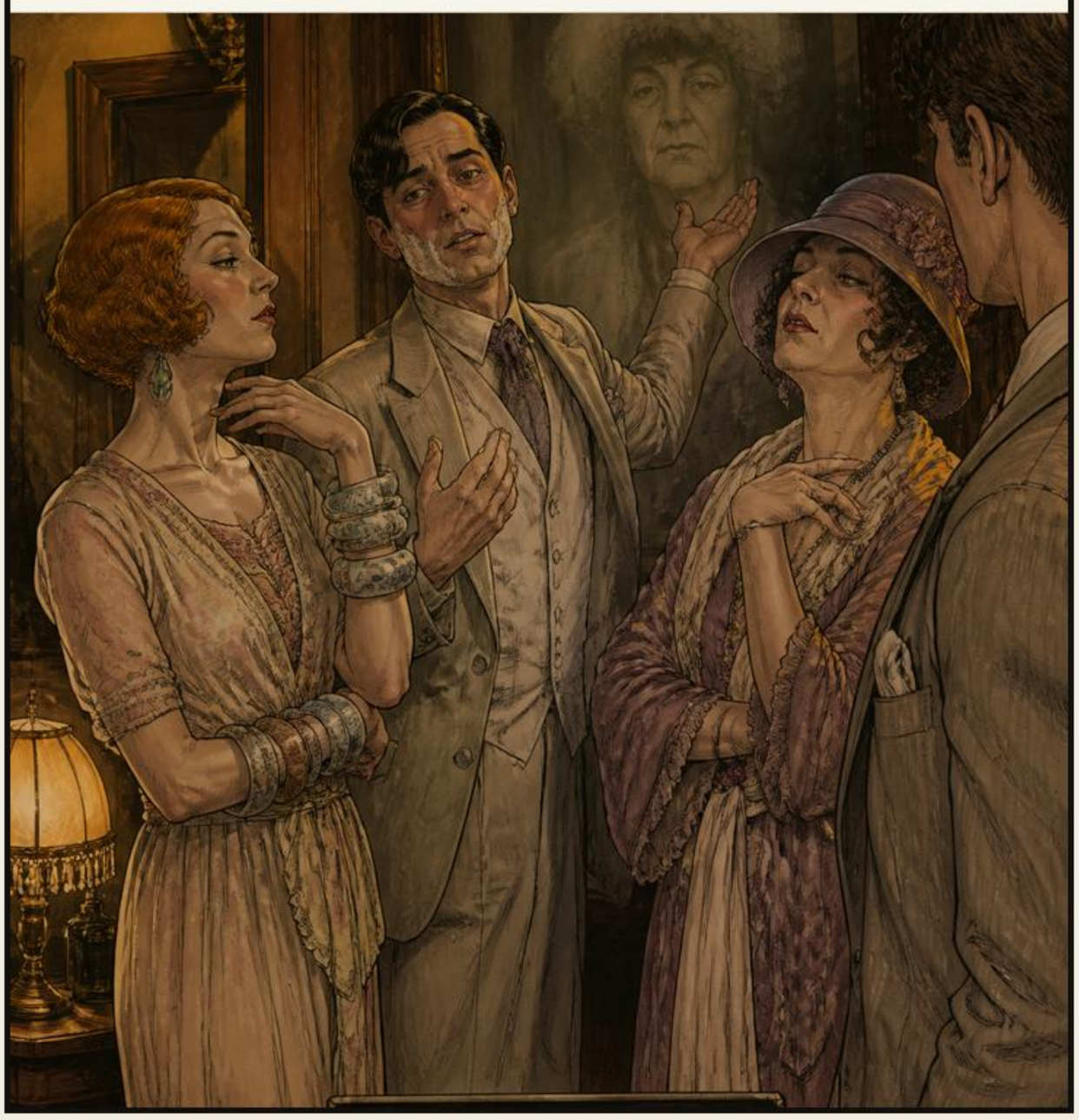


Tapestried Versailles, a hen that became an old lady, Town Tattle and Simon Called Peter—Myrtle saw to the dog, Tom unlocked the whisky. I have been drunk just twice in my life, and the second time was that afternoon.

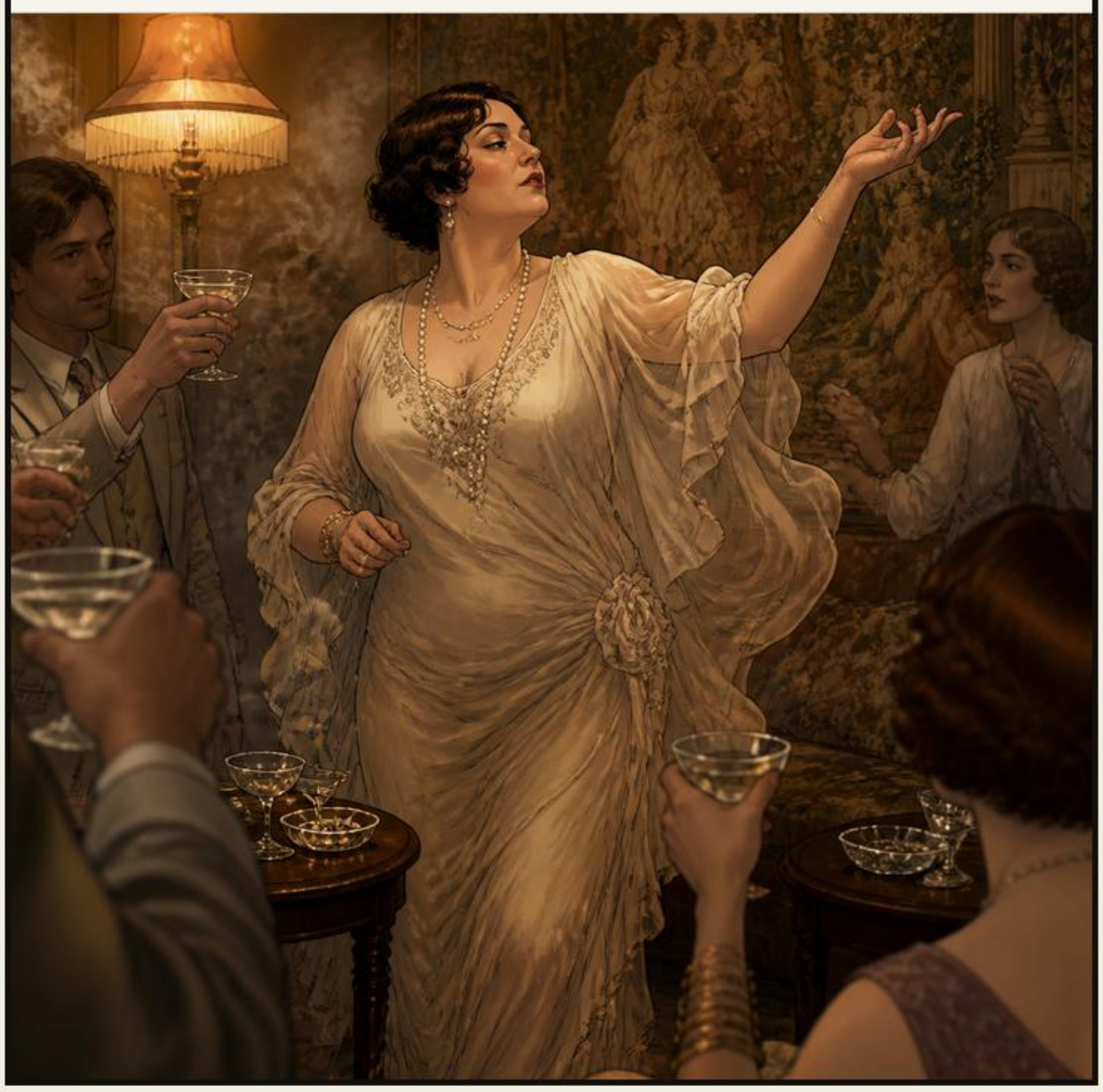
When I came back they had both disappeared. I sat in the living-room and read a chapter of Simon Called Peter—either it was terrible stuff or the whisky distorted things.



Her sister—a slender, worldly girl with powdered face and jangling bracelets—and a pale, feminine man from the flat below, a photographer, with his shrill, languid wife.



Her cream chiffon swept the room, and her vitality turned to impressive hauteur—orders for ice and mineral water, small disdain for the elevator boy, large airs for the small rooms.



The sister sat down beside me, lowering her voice with milky assurance about Tom and Myrtle—much of it lies.



I was within and without, enchanted and repelled by the inexhaustible variety of life—and Myrtle pulled her chair close, her warm breath pouring her first meeting with Tom over me.





“The two little seats facing each other—he had on a dress suit and patent leather shoes, and I couldn't keep my eyes off him. In the station his white shirtfront pressed against my arm. When I got into the taxi with him I kept thinking, over and over, you can't live forever, you can't live forever.”

Her artificial laughter rang through the room. Myrtle began listing the things she meant to buy and do.





The little dog sat blind in the smoke, groaning faintly, while people disappeared, reappeared, made plans, lost each other, and found each other a few feet away.

Toward midnight the second bottle was empty, and high talk piled drunk over the furniture. Tom and Myrtle were arguing whether she had any right to mention Daisy's name. Myrtle Wilson spoke.



Making a short deft movement, Tom broke her nose with his open hand. Then bloody towels on the bathroom floor, women's voices scolding, and high over it all a long broken wail of pain — while on the couch she bled fluently, trying to spread a copy of Town Tattle over the tapestried scenes of Versailles.



The photographer turned and continued out the door. I took my hat from thechandelier and followed. Mr. McKee apologized that he had not known he was touching the lever



... and I was standing beside his bed, and he was sitting up between the sheets in his underwear, a great portfolio in his hands — Beauty and the Beast ... Loneliness ... Old Grocery Horse ... Brook'n Bridge ...

